VSSC, situated in the capital city of Kerala, was ruled out. Some suggested we set up the test facility at Sriharikota, where ISRO had 26,000 acres of land. We already had the solid propellant test stand there, but I was against setting up the new facility because it didn't make safety sense to do firing at a site close to our launch pads. An accident at the test facility could jeopardize our launch facility. Such is the importance other spacefaring nations give their launch pads that they are not just supremely protected and maintained, there is always a second or third pad at a distant location. It beats me even today why India has not set up a back-up launch pad outside Sriharikota. (Both the pads now are close to each other, in Sriharikota.)

These people—evidently those who were not keen on liquid propulsion system—pushed for Sriharikota as the site so much that Dhawan was considering the suggestion. When I kept opposing, Dhawan told me that it makes sense to have it in Sriharikota because anyway there are going to be propellant storage tanks there. I told him those near the launch site would store only one and a half times the propellant needed for a launch, while a test complex will store propellant needed for maybe five tests. Also, we can't have the brain in Trivandrum and the muscle in Balasore. The facilities have to be co-located. In that case, I said, you shift the entire facility to Sriharikota. Dhawan smiled. He knew it was not possible, and would lead to much public and media outcry.

A Malayalam daily, incidentally, wrote a story saying I was trying to take away the space facility from Kerala to Andhra. That did it.

Not many know that Sriharikota itself was not ISRO's first choice for a launch pad. It was one of the few sites identified by senior ISRO scientist R M Vasagam, another being a place south of Nagapattinam. Both were in Tamil Nadu. For launching polar satellites, it was clear to us, our launch pad has to be on the eastern coast. Launching the rocket along the spin of the earth, it gave a huge advantage of cost; also by manouevring the rocket to the south after its initial eastward journey, we avoid flying over any landmass. The coastline of Kanyakumari was considered in the late 1960s, but a terrible mishandling by the government of Tamil Nadu, and a timely pitch by Andhra Pradesh, made Sriharikota happen.